

6.1 Self-Assessment: Identifying Your Subgenre

Answer the three questions below and note which subgenre column you check most often. That is your starting calibration.

1. When emotional tension peaks in your manuscript, does the scene:

- ☐ Resolve within the same chapter, with warmth and controlled spikes → **Contemporary Romance** lean
- ☐ Sustain for multiple chapters, building to a sharp, potentially devastating crack → **Dark Romance** lean
- ☐ Cycle quickly through deflection, humor, and brief moments of sincerity → **Rom-Com** lean
- ☐ Get interrupted by external danger, creating an uneven push-pull rhythm → **Romantic Suspense** lean
- ☐ Stretch across multiple scenes, delayed by social convention and propriety → **Historical Romance** lean

2. When your characters speak, the unspoken meaning underneath their words is:

- ☐ Visible to the reader within two to three exchanges → **Contemporary Romance** lean
- ☐ Partially hidden for five to eight exchanges, sensed rather than seen → **Dark Romance** lean
- ☐ Playful, light, and woven through the humor → **Rom-Com** lean
- ☐ Layered with trust and suspicion in every exchange → **Romantic Suspense** lean
- ☐ Carrying most of the emotional weight because direct expression is forbidden → **Historical Romance** lean

3. The emotional release in your scenes arrives:

- ☐ Steadily, within the scene itself → **Contemporary Romance** lean
- ☐ After a long build, then suddenly and sharply → **Dark Romance** lean
- ☐ In brief, sharp moments between rapid exchanges → **Rom-Com** lean
- ☐ Unevenly, interrupted by plot pressure → **Romantic Suspense** lean
- ☐ Slowly, delayed by what cannot be said aloud → **Historical Romance** lean

My subgenre: [YOUR_SUBGENRE]